On December 26, I met with Charles Schneeman, one of the more popular and successful science-fiction illustrators of the time. It was the first time I had met him. He was a handsome man, who looked younger than his thirty-three years; talkative, energetic, full of enthusiasm.

He had written me a few letters earlier in which he had spoken without details, of a project he had in mind. Now he told me about it. He wanted to do a science-fiction strip of the quality of "Terry and the Pirates," he to do the drawing and I to do the continuity.

I was dazzled by the project (especially by Schneeman's predictions as to the money we could make on it), and before the furlough was over I had written up some continuity for a sample Sunday strip and eventually got it to him.

Schneeman prepared one strip, finally, and it looked beautiful but nothing ever came of it. Nevertheless, it was the first time that I looked beyond the routine of writing for the science-fiction mazagines themselves.

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On December 30, I met Fred Pohl at the candy store. He had been in the Army for thirty-two months, had achieved the rank of sergeant, and had just been discharged that month. He had been in Italy and in France during the war but had not seen actual action.

He said, "My AGCT score was 156. What was yours?" I reddened (I know I did, because I felt myself redden) and said, "I got 160, Fred."

"Shit!" he said.

He didn't doubt me for a minute. I would have been dreadfully hurt if he had —not at his questioning my ability to get the score, but at his thinking I would lie just to put him down.

He was full of news about the Futurians. He himself was divorced and remarried. His second wife, a WAC captain, was still in Europe. Dick Wilson was in Tokyo; Cyril Kornbluth had been in the Battle of the Bulge; and Don Wollheim was suing Robert Lowndes for $25,ooo. 6

And so the year of 1945 drew to its close. It had been a dreadful year in some ways, filled first with apprehension of induction, and then of induction itself and the dull and toilsome life of a private in basic training.